

Get Things Done through Coalitions

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What do the American Paper Institute, National Coffee Association, Milk Industry Foundation, and American Council on Education have in common?

It may seem unlikely, but the answer is "an interest in sewer user charges."

These four associations and 11 others formed the Coalition for ICR Repeal to protect their members' interests in sewer user charges. Coalition members term industrial cost recovery (ICR) as "an unfair, unnecessary, and costly provision of the 1972 Federal Water Pollution Control Act."

This particular example of a coalition illustrates two very important points that you, a leader of your association, should be aware of. First of all, the coalition was successful. The industrial cost recovery provision was repealed on October 1, 1980, and coalition members frankly admit that they could never have done it alone. It took the efforts and—even more important—the clout of all 15 members to accomplish their goal.

The second point is this: Coalition members seemed like unlikely allies. Who would have thought they had anything in common?

"It's an interesting conglomeration of business groups with one similar interest," acknowledges Sheldon E. Steinbach, general counsel for the American Council on Education, Washington. "We all had one common problem—a proposed increase in sewer user charges."

"I remember the stunned look on the faces of the people at the first coalition meeting," he says with a chuckle. "They found out quickly that my association had the exact concern theirs did."

WHO ARE YOUR ALLIES?

Right now, your association is probably a member of a coalition. But do you know what the coalition's purpose is? If you don't, ask your association's chief paid officer. He or she usually represents an association's interests in a coalition effort.

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And while you are talking to your chief paid officer, ask what other associations comprise the coalition. You could be surprised. Like the Coalition for ICR Repeal, their names might not suggest a tie-in with your association's cause. In fact, they may be the names of associations that have been adversaries or competitors in the past.

It's not all that unusual, says Mr. Steinbach. "We look for common cause with other groups. We may be allies on one cause and enemies on another. It's happened time after time."

It's important to overlook past differences and concentrate on the present goal of the coalition, agrees Dr. Paul A. Kerschner, associate director for legislation, research, and programs at the National Retired Teachers Association/American Association of Retired Persons, Washington. "Two organizations can be in deep dissent on some issues," he says. "On those issues, we know we disagree. But on the issues where we do agree, it's much more powerful to speak in a unified voice."

Of course, sometimes your association's allies are obvious. Such was the case when the Distributive Services Committee was formed 17 years ago. Eighteen Ohio associations whose members were involved in distributing formed the coalition to reduce property tax on retail inventory. At the time, the tax was 70 percent of the value of the inventory. The coalition has successfully obtained several reductions since its formation, and the coalition's goal of a 35 percent inventory tax will go into effect in two years.

In this case, both the allies and the enemy were obvious. The allies: trade associations with retail merchant members. The enemy: the state legislature.

SO MANY SUCCESS STORIES

Case after case of association coalitions that have been successful in their pursuits can be cited. William T. Robinson, CAE, senior vice president of the American Hospital Association, Chicago, relates one coalition success story.

Several years ago, he says, the annual rate of increase in the level of expenditures for health care was out of control. Predictions were that if health care costs continued at the same rate it would be necessary to spend the entire gross national product on health care alone by the year 2010. In fact, the government's outlay for health care—Medicare and Medicaid—was beginning to compete with the defense budget.

Government officials, concerned, issued a challenge to the health care field to voluntarily control the rate of increase. A coalition called Voluntary Effort was created. It represented the interests of trade associations, commercial insurance companies, and others. Now, three years after the start of the coalition, "the rate of increase has been sufficiently retarded," Mr. Robinson says.

Edie Fraser, president of Fraser/Associates, Washington, has been involved in enough similar success stories to become a firm believer in their power. "Coalitions are the new trend in business relations on policy issues," she says. "I believe they are the most effective means of achieving results."

WHAT'S THEIR PURPOSE?

She explains that the basic purpose of a coalition is "to join forces together behind a mutual interest—generally a policy issue—and work together for common effectiveness and results."

"More and more associations are recognizing the power of coalitions," Ms. Fraser continues, "because they can achieve far more by integrating their resources and dividing the effort behind a common cause."

Paul Korody, director of public affairs for the National Meat Association, Washington, says coalitions are growing in numbers in response to a changing Congress. "Within the past 10 years, we have seen a decentralization of power on Capitol Hill. Today, every congressman is almost as important as another. They all have to be talked to."

That means, he says, that only the really large associations with members in every congressional district can tackle an issue alone.

The rest of us have to pool our memberships to be effective in Congress. Whereas we have a lot of meatpackers in the Northwest and Southwest, there are many congressional districts where we have no members at all. We would be less effective in those states [without a coalition]. By combining resources with a number of associations with different memberships but the same goals, you can cover the country.

He adds that, in most cases, congressional staffs appreciate a coalition's efforts. Why? Because it makes their jobs that much easier. They can get one document or have one conversation with a coalition leader and know who and how many are for or against an issue. That's in lieu of speaking with 50,000—a number that five association executives involved in a coalition can easily represent.

CHOOSING A LEADER

In order for any coalition to be successful, it has to have a leader or coordinator with a commitment to the cause and time to devote to it, says Sheldon Steinbach, American Council on Education.

The effectiveness of the ICR repeal was solely due to the continuous scrutiny and daily monitoring of one person.

A coalition functions only when one person is given responsibility to make that issue move. Someone must call the shots. A leader must have ample time to spend on the issue, almost to the point of making it his or her primary preoccupation.

Because of the considerable time requirement, choosing a coalition coordinator is often simply a process of elimination. Who has the time to spend on it? Who was the expertise on the issue?

When these questions are answered, only a few eligibles are likely to remain. Usually it's the executive of the association which the outcome of the issue most affects.

Or as Ms. Fraser puts it, "The leader usually represents the one association that has the most to gain . . . or lose."

GUIDELINES FOR EFFECTIVENESS

Obviously, the selection of the leader can either make or break a coalition. But other factors also enter into the outcome of your association's coalition.

Here are just a few elements common to successful coalition efforts:

- A commitment by members to work, not in their own self-interest, but in the interest of the group.
- Expertise on the part of all members on the subject matter and its ramifications.
- Knowledge of how the legislature—either state or federal—works.
- Ability to plan a strategy and allow enough lead time to develop it in detail so nothing slips through the cracks and is left undone.
- Communication with members of the coalition—whether it's through meetings, newsletters, memos, or telephone calls.
- Keeping on the offensive, rather than the defensive. "Use facts, data, and public opinion to build on your important points," Ms. Fraser says. "It's not necessary to attack your opposition." She ticks off campaign after campaign that was lost because one side began to react defensively to the opposition.
- Member involvement. "If the issue is important to your members—and it should be or you shouldn't be part of the coalition—get them involved," Ms. Fraser urges. "The grassroots campaign is important. The work should really come from members; your association should serve as the catalyst."
- Latitude from you and your board of directors. "Our board sets broad policy," says John C. Mahaney, Jr., president of the Ohio Council of Retail Merchants in Columbus. "After that, my board leaves me alone. It doesn't tie the staff's hands."

A COMMITMENT TO GO

The last point, the latitude you give to your chief paid executive, can be a crucial item to your association's contribution to the coalition. "The board gives us a broad delegation of authority," Sheldon Steinbach says. "We are paid to exercise good judgment and proceed. If you are hamstrung, it will slow you down, if not completely cripple your coalition."

He explains that if he had to go back to his board of directors every time a decision was made in a coalition, he would lose valuable time—not to mention the confidence of other coalition members.

SURVEY OF MEMBERSHIP

To make sure his board of directors will agree with his decisions, Mr. Steinbach surveys his membership on major issues that concern the association. "If they think it is important, they tell us to go," he says. "But they don't tell us how to go."

Dr. Kerschner explains that the only time he goes back to his board for a coalition decision is when the issue is controversial and the association's stance involves a change in previous policy.

What do you do with dissent among coalition members?" asks Dr. Kerschner. "How do you handle it? Do you avoid the issue? Do you go with the majority?"

He explains that chief paid officers must answer these questions, and answer them adequately, for a coalition to work. He has found one possible answer for the coalitions

he has been involved with: If there is a disagreement on one particular point of an issue, the dissenting party removes his or her name and endorsement from that specific letter but continues to endorse the remainder of the issue.

"Trade-offs are important because one small issue can divide the coalition," he says. "Before you say 'I will not sign that,' look at all sides. You might have to make a compromise. Internal negotiations are necessary to present a united front to those you are dealing with."

GOODWILL A KEY INGREDIENT

William Robinson advises associations to go into a coalition with the idea that there might have to be a trade-off. "Your pet ideas are going to be examined by others," he says.

You might have to accept the fact that the publicity will be given to the coalition and not to your association. A coalition takes goodwill by the participants. Sometimes the goodwill is there in the beginning; sometimes it takes time for it to grow.

Speaking realistically, Edie Fraser says it almost never happens that members of a coalition agree on every item, every detail of a coalition.

That's where the art of negotiation is important. The common end of the allies is more important than the priority of any one association.

SHARING IN THE GLORY

You may wonder why your association's past efforts in coalitions have not been more heavily publicized . . . why your association didn't take more credit for the outcome.

"A coalition, to be effective, is without limelight or glory for the association involved," says Paul Korody.

The purpose is to get a particular job done. We're there to serve our members, and coalitions are the more effective means of doing that. Any glory is in the fact that we satisfactorily served our members.

Sheldon Steinbach admits that sharing the spotlight is a problem for some associations. Sometimes, they are so greedy for the recognition that they won't participate in a coalition—and risk losing the fight. Other times, they might participate in a coalition, but afterward they will attempt to garner all of the credit for their association alone.

When William Robinson was working on Voluntary Effort, he says that the businesses and associations involved had no qualms about giving complete credit to the coalition, not to themselves. "It would have been counterproductive to publish under any one member's name," Mr. Robinson says. "We wanted the coalition to become a familiar name . . . to have its own identity."

POTENTIAL PROBLEMS

Powerful though they may be, coalitions are not perfect. Problems arise, and they have to be alleviated before the cause can be won. Here are some snags that can occur. With negotiation, respect, and planning, all can be overcome.

1. *One member dominates.* Sometimes, when a coalition is composed of one or two large, domineering associations and a variety of small ones, representatives from the smaller associations are not given the chance to express their opinions. Or, if they are given the opportunity, they are not given priority. All members must listen to one another.
2. *Jealousy between members.* This usually occurs at the outset, Ms. Fraser points out, until coalition members realize that "they can achieve far more by integrating their resources and dividing the effort behind a common cause."
3. *Conflicting goals.* "You've got to go for the greatest good for the greatest number," Mr. Steinbach says.
4. *Conflicting strategy.* This occurs most often when two or more coalition members have considerable legislative experience. Because of their backgrounds, each thinks his own plan of attack is best.
5. *Minor disagreements.* Even though the association executives agree on the major issue, they sometimes bicker about a minor part of it. "You can't let a specific point divide and conquer the group," Dr. Kerschner says.
6. *Too formal.* Dr. Kerschner differentiates between organization, which you can never have enough of, and formalization, which you can. He says it's important to remember that each member of the coalition has an association to which he is responsible and that the coalition should not become a substitute for it.
7. *Too many meetings.* Some coalitions are permanent. Others are temporary—disbanded as soon as their cause is settled. Dr. Kerschner warns that members of permanent coalitions have to be careful not to call a meeting just to be calling a meeting. Unless a crisis has occurred or a new development has come up, he recommends meeting about once a month. Between meetings, he uses the phone for exchanges of information.
8. *Lack of follow-through.* Sometimes a coalition member will slip up, and the work assigned to him or her will not get done. If that happens, and it is not caught in time, all of the coalition efforts will be wasted.

EVERYONE'S DOING IT

Coalitions are not limited to associations. Business groups, consumer groups—just about any group you can think of is involved in some type of coalition. "On any side of any issue, you can find a coalition that has formed, is being formed, or will be formed," Mr. Korody says.

Whatever type of coalition your association may now be involved in, your chances of victory are better through unity. Mr. Mahaney firmly believes Ohio merchants would not have received inventory tax relief without the Distributive Service Committee. "We could not have done it alone," he states. "It took everyone in the coalition to do it."

"Sometimes a coalition is the only way to do something," he continues. "Especially now, as the problems become more complex. It seems like they are too big for any one—or even two—associations to handle."

Paul Korody couldn't agree more. "A smart association executive seeks his peers and works through a coalition. The days of trying to do it all yourself are long gone."

Twenty Tips for Making a Coalition Work

If you aren't convinced of the value of coalitions, talk to Edie Fraser, president of Fraser/Associates, Washington, D.C. She's a firm believer in the effectiveness of coalitions and presents a persuasive argument on their behalf.

She asserts that coalitions are the wave of the future. "On most policy issues, a coalition is the only way to go—if you have a common interest," she says.

In her opinion, more and more association executives are recognizing the potential—and power—of coalitions, but they aren't sure how to proceed. "Carrying out the program is where they often fall down."

Here are her 20 rules for participating in an effective coalition:

1. Clearly define issues and strategy.
 2. Determine a timetable and needs.
 3. Identify both allies and opposition.
 4. Build constituency and recruit allies.
 5. Select leadership from within allies.
 6. Devise a clear plan of action.
 7. Determine resources, budget, and meet those needs.
 8. Divide up tasks within the coalition.
 9. Establish a working task force or executive committee.
 10. Keep coalition members informed and involved.
 11. Establish a communication program plan; clearly distribute tasks.
 12. Build supportive case materials.
 13. Develop an internal communication program with each association involving its members.
 14. Enlist experts to support the coalition's case.
 15. Explain the issue in economic impact terms when possible; use appropriate public opinion.
 16. Utilize all pertinent media for greatest impact.
 17. Remember to keep all coalition constituents informed and involved.
 18. If it's a legislative issue, review the congressional strategy on a regular basis.
 19. Determine if the coalition leadership is serving as a catalyst for communication.
 20. Prove the results and communicate them to the member constituencies.
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